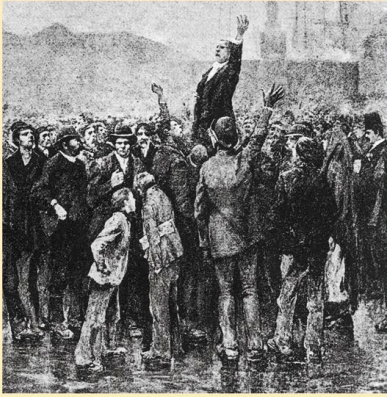




A labor leader addresses dockers during the London dockworkers' strike of 1889.

The 1889 London Dock Strike

By the 1880s, unskilled British manual workers were becoming increasingly dissatisfied with poor pay, dangerous working conditions, and long hours. Trade unions had previously largely only represented skilled workers but low-skilled workers saw the power of collective bargaining and they too began to organize.

In 1889, dockworkers in London went on strike over pay, demanding a rate of sixpence an hour (known as the “docker’s tanner”). All levels of dockworkers were

included in the action and it is estimated that up to 130,000 went on strike, bringing the docks to a standstill for 5 weeks. As a result of this mass industrial action, the dock owners agreed to the majority of the workers’ demands, thereby bringing the strike to a close. The success of the dockers’ strike inspired many more unskilled workers to join trade unions, swelling their collective membership in the UK to over 2 million by 1899.

Trade Union Act. This mitigated the common law of restraint of trade (any action that prevents free competition in the market), which had previously made trade union rules impossible to enforce. Although the Trade Union Act secured the legal status of trade unions and protected their funds from embezzlement, this did not mean the government supported industrial action—it also passed the Criminal Law Amendment Act, which made picketing illegal. Trade unions were now legal, but anyone taking industrial action could still be legally penalized, leaving them as vulnerable to prosecution as before.

Other changes were taking place, however. In 1867, 1 million working-class men won the right to vote, and the 1874 election saw two working men elected to Parliament for the first time. Now that they had a political voice, working people no longer had to rely on sympathy from the liberal middle classes to further their agenda. Growing political activism within the working class was echoed in the establishment of the Trades Union Congress (TUC) in 1868. The TUC quickly grew in membership, and one of its first campaigns was to lobby against the

Criminal Law Amendment Act—its repeal in 1875 handed back to workers the power to strike.

In 1901, however, the Taff Vale Railway Company of South Wales took the Amalgamated Society of Railway Servants (ASRS) to court after the railway workers went on strike for better pay and union recognition. The employers demanded compensation for the days lost to the strike, but the ASRS argued that as a trade union it was neither a corporation nor an individual and therefore could not

be held liable. The judge disagreed and ruled against the ASRS, meaning that unions could now be sued for taking strike action. As a result, unions could no longer afford to strike.

The Trade Disputes Act

Many workers, who felt that the Taff Vale judgment was unfair, joined the recently formed Labour Party, and between 1900 and 1906, the number of Labour MPs rose from 2 to 29. The 1906 general election returned a Liberal government and many more Labour MPs, who had campaigned to overturn the ruling. As a result, the Trade Disputes Act was passed in 1906—trade unions could no longer be sued for taking strike action. They flourished in the UK until the 1980s, when a Conservative government, hostile to the trade unions, reduced their power after the mine workers’ strike of 1984–1985.

Globally, about 350 million workers are organized into trade unions, but labor rights are under pressure as the digital economy sheds unskilled workers and global trade relies greatly on cheap, unregulated labor in the developing world. ■



The purposes of any trade union shall not ... be deemed to be unlawful so as to render any member of such trade union liable to criminal prosecution.

Trade Union Act

